

hospital? At The Cradle, Bangalore, a luxury car will be at your beck and call. No matter how friendly the ads and cheery the ambience, hospitals are not hotels, you thought. But the new generation birthing centres mushrooming across the country are turning that conventional wisdom upside down. But lavish personalised care is not just the forte of high-end birthing centres. Now multispecialties are entering that zone too (see chart).

Hospitals are now finding ways to reach more patients and expand their business. Retail clinics like Manipal Cure and Care (MCC) in Bangalore are unique in that they complement the hospital business by providing feel-good, look-good care. A brain-wave of the Manipal Hospital group, MCC offers a mix of world-class products and services in preventive, wellness and beauty—from health packages to skin care products, premium exercise machines, anti-snoring nasal devices to cosmeceuticals. “I am an active proponent of this in-

tegrated approach, especially the wellness to prevention route,” says Dr Ranjan Pai, managing director, Manipal Education and Medical Group, Bangalore. That makes perfect business sense in an age when Generation-X does not want to get into hospitals for services that can be rendered in a “non-sick” environment. “They prefer being served in boutique ambience, where service standards and the assurance of the genuineness of clinical care would be a significant pull,” he adds.

New Models, New Terrain

“Improving the lives of billions of people at the bottom of the economic pyramid is a noble endeavour. It can also be a lucrative one,” so says management guru C.K. Prahalad. New business models in Indian health-care back up that theory. Ask Dr Ashwin Naik, 37, and Dr Veerendra Hiremath, 35, who grew up in Hubli, Karnataka, went around the world and returned to set up Vaatsalya, a unique model of affordable hospital network in under-served tier II and III towns. “Doctors from rural districts rarely go back to their roots,” says Naik. They decided to address this demand-supply gap. When Vaatsalya started, they tapped into their NRI friends and family to chip in. “They gave easily because everyone wants to connect to their roots.” Venture funds began contributing gradually, both

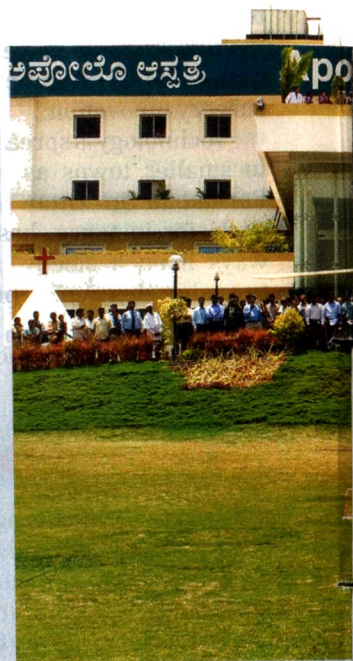
Rs 5,400 cr
is the value of the wellness market, growing at a fast clip of 35% a year

5%
of household income goes to healthcare; 70% is sought from the private sector

New Facilities

Air Ambulance

It is the most ‘in’ thing in the hospital circuit today with almost every super specialty hospital, over 24 in the NCR region alone, offering the service. With top-drawer emergency doctors on-board, it’s a much-needed service for patients who can’t reach hospitals easily or on time. Many hospitals like the Apollo, Hyderabad, and Akshaya Apollo, Ahmedabad, have their own helipads. The cost can run into lakhs depending on the distance.



Boutique Hospitals

More money, more attention. Lavish personalised care was so long the forte of high-end birthing centres. Now Multi-specialties are entering that zone. Check out two upcoming hospitals of Mumbai—SevenHills in Marol Andheri and PD Hinduja at Khar—that are gearing up to offer this service—green sprawl, designer suites, spas, fine dining—to patients who expect country club facilities while in a hospital.

Bar-coded OPD card

Be it Paras Hospital in Gurgaon or the brand new Desun Hospital & Heart Institute in Kolkata—bar-coded smart cards to track patient details are fast catching the fancy of hospital planners. These are issued the first time a patient visits a hospital. The unique computer generated registration number would not only hold good every time the patient visits, it would also give the hospital instant access to his/her profile.

